Reimagining Early English Drama: Recentering Historical Narratives using the LEAF Platform

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In the Semantic Web, data points across the internet are linked, allowing for the exchange of structured information across projects.The promise of the Semantic Web for humanities scholars is that through this exchange with other researchers we can improve our understanding of our own subject matter, at the same time that we contribute to enhancing the work of broader scholarly communities with which we would not otherwise interconnect. Now, we need to consider how this semantic data helps us to shape the narratives that assist us in answering our humanistic research questions. Digital environments that support cultural data production and publication workflows, like the Linked Editing Academic Framework (LEAF), can serve as spaces in which different narratives can be synthesized. In this paper, we will report on our work in the REED London Online project to date, and demonstrate how combining the historical records and data in REED London within the LEAF platform will facilitate our goal of enhancing research-rich historical narratives. We will also model ways in which LEAF might serve as a combinatory space where other scholars can join us for this work.

REED London is a dynamic digital resource that offers new approaches for reading, analyzing, and configuring archival and editorial materials, showcasing performance events in early modern London to reveal hitherto unexplored stories about the City and its occupants. This long-term project was begun in 2017, funded by the Mellon Foundation and NEH, and developed in partnership with the Collaboratory for Writing and Research on Culture (CWRC). REED London in turn develops from the Records of Early English Drama (REED), a four-decades long project dedicated to drawing together evidence of music, theatre, and performance in England, Scotland, and Wales from 1100-1642.The sources include play texts, financial records, and firsthand accounts of performance events, which we present through annotated texts that focus on named entities, as well as through a variety of temporospatial visualizations.To date we have focused on events spanning over a century of early modern London history, including those surrounding the Coronation of Elizabeth I in 1558/9 and the Wedding Performances for Princess Elizabeth Stuart, concentrating on the role of gender in the accounts of each. In presenting these events, we also demonstrate the relationship between Worshipful Companies, legal fraternities, aristocracy, and religious officials in the development and enactment of early modern performance. The work we have undertaken on REED London has evolved, from a data-capture/resurrection project, to one in which we discover the unexpected in our sources, to one in which we provide a platform to commune with other researchers and complicate the historical record.

REED London is housed in Linked Editing Academic Framework (LEAF): an open-access editorial platform for production, collaboration, and publication. LEAF supports digital methods including text encoding and annotating, data mining and visualizations, and makes data discoverable on the Semantic Web through a suite of tools in Linked Infrastructure for Networked Cultural Scholarship (LINCS) – LEAF's sister project. The bidirectional data bridge between LEAF and LINCS can support the kind of narrative generation that we envision.

To test our theory about creating narratives from digitally-analyzed and enriched cultural data, we are focusing on two well-documented event-sets that took place in London 75 years apart. Both events involve royal families – and in particular concentrate on gendered subjects.

1. Princess Elizabeth Stuart's marriage to Frederick V (1612/13). The prolific letter-writer John Chamberlain wrote extensive accounts of the wedding celebrations to several correspondents, but his descriptions vary significantly based on who he was corresponding with. A close semantic reading of the letters Chamberlain wrote to Alice Carleton and her brother Dudley give very accounts – we believe, in part, because of the gender of the recipient. We hope to demonstrate that analyzing these letters linked with much larger complementary data sets can lead to a more nuanced understanding of this dynastic wedding.

2. Elizabeth I's Coronation (1558/59). Using a different approach, we have cobbled together a multi-witness composite of the events leading up to Elizabeth's ascension – especially the contributions made by London's Worshipful Companies to the processions and performances held throughout the City. For this work, we are interleaving a variety of contemporary documents, including Guild and Common Council account books and the published diaries and chronicles by Henry Machyn, Raphael Holinshed, and John Stow. In this case, we hope to complicate understanding of societal connections between the new monarch and working Londoners.

In LEAF, as we encode these documents we capture named entities connected with the events (people, places, and organizations), we analyze connections among them using LEAF's Dynamic Table of Contexts (DToC) and open-source spatial and temporal tools like Peripleo and Timeline JS. In terms of the Chamberlain letters, we are able to present the two Carleton letters using DToC to analyze where Chamberlain's narrative varies (Figure 1). Using Peripleo we can generate entity-tagged maps that connect locations to Chamberlain's description of events (Figure 2). For Elizabeth's coronation, we are reading across the disparate records in DToC, and considering the coronation procession not only in City spaces, but also how the events evolved over time using Timeline JS (Figure 3). Because DToC, Peripleo, and Timeline JS can all be embedded within LEAF, we are able to triangulate our analysis and draw upon it to shape data-driven narratives. Because REED London is a LINCS-affiliated project, we are providing our linkable data in the hope that it will help us to better communicate our perspectives of these historical events with other scholars whose research is adjacent to ours, and from these communications will develop collaborative narratives drawn from many datasets.

By DH2025, we will have have 1) fully encoded and analysed the correspondence between Chamberlain and the Carletons; 2) expanded the number of guild accounts and chronicle references of Elizabeth's coronation; and 3) published the linked data about these materials to LINCS with the connections back to the data-driven narratives in REED London.

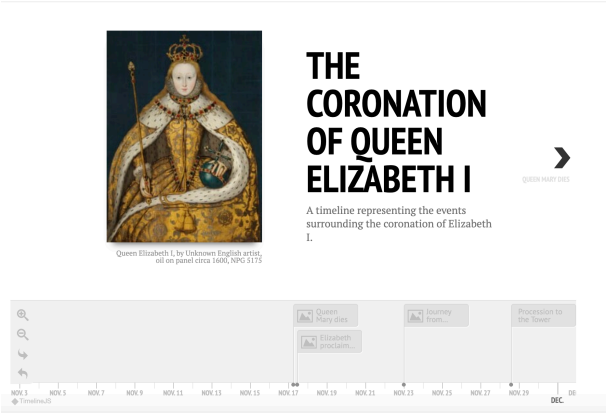

Figure 1: Dynamic Table of Contexts edition of John Chamberlain's letters.

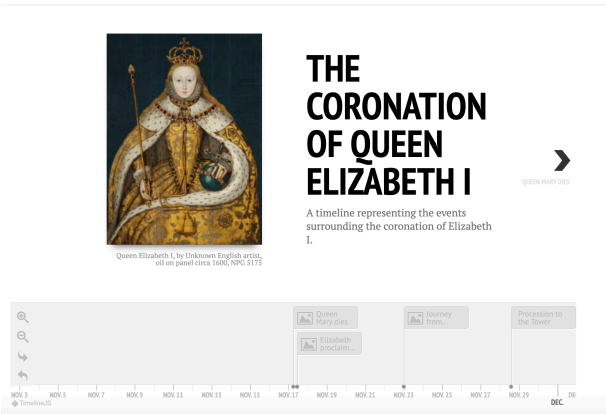

Figure 1: Dynamic Table of Contexts edition of John Chamberlain's letters.Figure 2: Guildhall locations in REED London using the Peripleo mapping tool

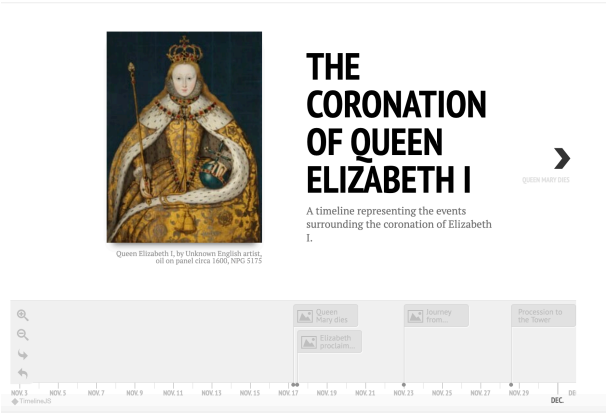

Figure 2: Guildhall locations in REED London using the Peripleo mapping tool Figure 3: The events leading up to Elizabeth I's coronation visualized with Timeline JS

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